

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Donald Trump criticised an **Israeli** strike on southern Beirut, saying it “should not have happened”. Israel said the attack was a response to drone fire by Hizbullah, a Lebanon-based militia. The American president also claimed that a [peace deal](#) with Iran was “very close”, but Iranian officials warned that the Beirut strike could jeopardise the agreement.

British armed forces seized a tanker carrying roughly 700,000 barrels of **Russian oil** in the English Channel. It is their first operation against Russia’s shadow fleet. The *Smyrtos* was boarded after Cameroon removed it from its shipping register. Sir Keir Starmer, Britain’s prime minister, said the move reminded “those fuelling Putin’s war in Ukraine that we will not let them hide.”

Mr Trump spoke separately with **Vladimir Putin** and **Volodymyr Zelensky**. According to the Kremlin, Mr Trump told Russia’s president that he was ready to work with Ukraine and America’s European allies to secure a ceasefire. The pair also discussed negotiations with Iran. Mr Zelensky said he had updated the American president on battlefield developments and would continue talks with him at this week’s G7 summit in France.

Preliminary results suggested **Swiss voters** had rejected a [proposal](#) to cap the country's population at 10m, by 54% to 46%, dealing a blow to the anti-immigration Swiss People's Party. The initiative would have obliged the government to curb population growth and could ultimately have put Switzerland's free-movement agreement with the EU at risk. Opponents argued it would worsen labour shortages and harm the economy.

The **European Commission** said it was assessing the consequences of an American order that prompted **Anthropic**, an artificial-intelligence company, to restrict access to its most advanced models. The company said it would disable Fable 5 and Mythos 5 after the Trump administration barred foreign nationals, including Anthropic's own foreign employees, from using them. A commission spokesman said the dispute highlighted the need for Europe to strengthen its tech sovereignty.

Tommy Robinson, a far-right agitator, was detained for around three hours at London's Heathrow airport under counter-terrorism legislation. He was returning to Britain from Russia via Turkey. Mr Robinson said police seized his phone before releasing him. The detention came after a week of [anti-immigrant riots](#) in Northern Ireland that politicians said had been amplified online by far-right activists.

The **New York Knicks** won their first National Basketball Association championship for 53 years. They beat the San Antonio Spurs 94-90 in San Antonio, their fourth win in the best-of-seven series. Joyous New Yorkers poured onto the streets to celebrate. Meanwhile, in the football **World Cup**, Brazil and Morocco played out a 1-1 draw, while Scotland beat Haiti 1-0. Australia caused an upset by beating Turkey.

Word of the week: SaaSocalypse, the widespread ruin that many fear AI will bring to the software-as-a-service industry. [But will it?](#)

Correction: In an earlier version of World in Brief we said that Viktor Orban had led Fidesz since 2010. In fact, he led the party from 1993 to 2000 and has done so again since 2003. He became Hungary's prime minister in 1998 and returned to office in 2010. Sorry.

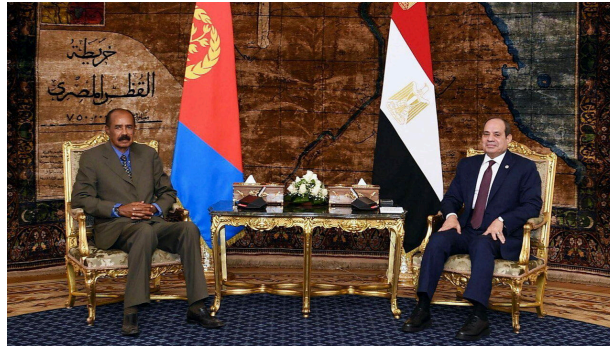


Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump's birthday bash

Thirty years ago the Ultimate Fighting Championship, a mixed-martial-arts promotion, was practically illegal across much of America. States banned its events; John McCain, then a senator, called it “human cockfighting”. How times have changed. On Sunday the UFC will hold a fight night outside the White House to mark Donald Trump's 80th birthday.

The partnership between the UFC's boss, [Dana White](#), and the president goes back decades. At first it was all business. Mr Trump welcomed the UFC at his Atlantic City casino when few others would. Then it turned political. Their alliance bolstered Mr Trump's transgressive, cartoonishly masculine image and helped him court [the “bro” vote](#) in the 2024 election. Now who can tell the difference between politics and business? The fight cage at the White House is plastered in ad copy. And on Saturday the Trump-aligned “super PAC” held a \$1m-a-head fundraiser at the president's golf club in Virginia—ostensibly an independent event, though one with overlapping guest lists.



Photograph: Getty Images

Danger in the Horn of Africa

Abdel-Fattah al-Sisi, Egypt's strongman, recently held talks in Cairo with Isaias Afwerki, [Eritrea's](#) dictator. Since 2024 the pair have met at least four times, a budding bromance forged in fear. Mr Isaias worries that Ethiopia's leader, [Abiy Ahmed](#), has expansionist designs on parts of his territory. He has cunningly made friends with the many [enemies of his enemy](#). These include Mr Sisi, whose government says an Ethiopian mega-dam on the Nile poses an "existential" threat to Egypt's water supply, and the Tigray People's Liberation Front, a heavily armed group that rules Tigray, Ethiopia's northernmost region.

Ethiopia is rattled. On Tuesday a government mouthpiece said the TPLF and Eritrea were "Pharaoh's horses riding to tighten Egypt's yoke of destruction upon Ethiopia". And on Thursday Ethiopia's top spy warned that the TPLF, "aided and abetted" by Eritrea, planned to launch a war against the government "in the coming days". Mr Isaias's long-awaited showdown with Mr Abiy seems dangerously close at hand.

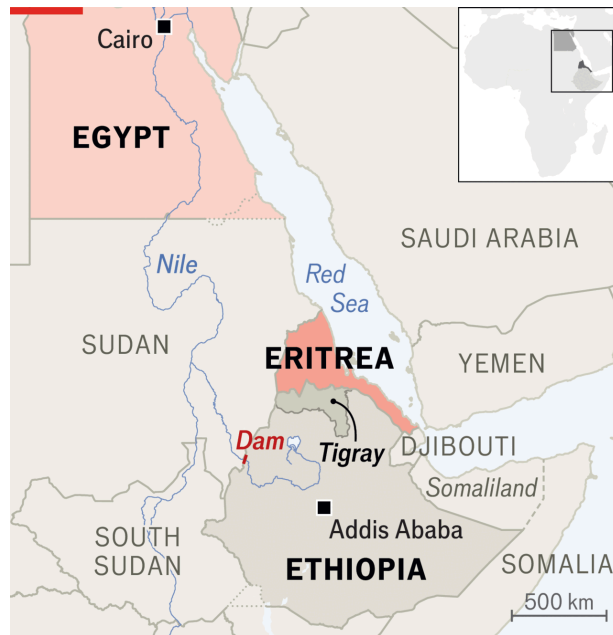


Image: The Economist



Photograph: Reuters

Europe's fighter-jet dilemmas

Last week Germany and France abandoned their effort, alongside Spain, to build a next-generation fighter jet. Officials could not resolve a dispute between French and German defence firms over how to share the work. Germany is now considering alternative options. One might be to join the [Global Combat Air Programme](#), a rival jet project shared between Britain, Italy and Japan. It aims to launch its plane, known as the Tempest in Britain, by 2035.

GCAP does not suffer from the industrial bickering that scuppered Germany's collaboration with France. But it has problems of its own. Britain's government has so far been unable to commit to a long-term joint contract for the project [as it struggles to raise defence spending](#). That frustrates Japanese officials. Japan's prime minister, Takaichi Sanae, is expected to visit London on Sunday to discuss the matter with her beleaguered British counterpart, Sir Keir Starmer. The prospect of attracting German investment in their jet set no doubt appeals.



Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Aiko, the princess barred from the Japanese throne

At New Year Emperor Naruhito and his family stepped onto a balcony at the Imperial Palace in Tokyo. Thousands of well-wishers waved Japanese flags and cheered. But it was 24-year-old Aiko, or Princess Toshi, who made the crowd swoon. As if awaiting a pop idol, some held fans emblazoned with her name.

Aiko is the emperor's only child. But she can never inherit the throne: [succession is restricted to men](#) and only passes through the male line. When she marries, Aiko will leave the imperial family and become a commoner.

That is a problem for the family. Japan's monarchy, the world's oldest, is running out of heirs. In recent decades royal men have fathered several girls but only one boy: 19-year-old Prince Hisahito, Naruhito's nephew. If he does not father a son, the 2,700-year-old imperial line will die out.

Aiko's popularity has encouraged more Japanese to think that should change. From a young age she showed public-spiritedness. As a schoolgirl she wrote a story about a nurse who heals injured animals. After college she worked for the Red Cross. Her public appearances have impressed people, too; during her first official overseas visit, to Laos in 2025, she clung to a toy elephant a sick child had given her, refusing to pass it to an aide. And many

Japanese regret the intense scrutiny her mother, Masako, faced for failing to produce an heir.

Japan's politicians are acutely aware. On June 10th leaders from the main political parties approved a proposal to amend the Imperial House Law to allow female royals to remain in the family after marriage. It would also enable royals to adopt children from imperial branch families that were stripped of royal status following the second world war (though they will not have succession rights). But the changes will still not let women rule.

Polls suggest that 90% of Japanese support a female emperor. Last year the country [elected its first female prime minister](#), Takaichi Sanae. And there is even a comic-book series that argues for Aiko to become monarch. But Japan is still ranked 27th of 29 countries in *The Economist's* [glass-ceiling index](#), which measures how women fare in the workplace. It may be a while yet before a woman sits on the Chrysanthemum Throne.

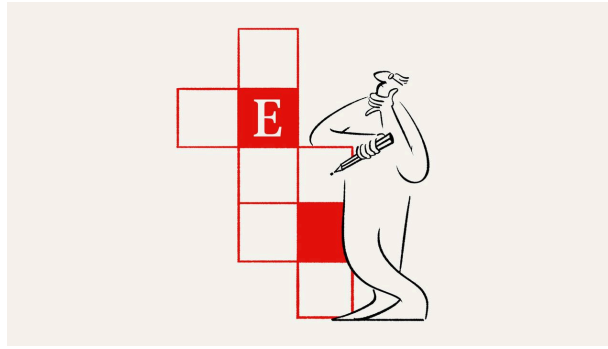


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - South-west makes way for HR in sorrow, disgust (6)

2 across - Voyage the first time roads are vacant, evading lawlessness (6)

3 across - Hesitation after abnormal baby prattle (6)

1 down - Out of place, I spit at holy, warm reception (11)

Straight clues

1 across - _ show, _ film, _ -struck – scary! (6)

2 across - It usually requires many steps, but in basketball it only needs two or three (6)

3 across - Australian chatter (6)

1 down - The Greek concept “Xenia” that Zeus loved to test on humans (11)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Cheryl Bernhardt, Calgary, Canada

Lungile Thabo Twalo, Johannesburg, South Africa

Kathryn Voegeli, Uetikon am See, Switzerland

They gave the correct answers of Monterrey, Vancouver, Philadelphia, Guadalajara and Atlanta. The theme is they are all venues for the 2026 football World Cup.

The questions were

Monday: What is the capital of the Mexican state of Nuevo León?

Tuesday: Stanley Park is a large public park in which North American city?

Wednesday: The First Continental Congress met in 1774 in which city?

Thursday: What is the capital of the Mexican state of Jalisco?

Friday: Which American city has the busiest airport in the world, in terms of passenger traffic?

*No intelligent idea can gain
general acceptance unless some
stupidity is mixed in with it.*

Fernando Pessoa